



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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In the ashes of Ningbo, Samrat Rana found the spark that would, two months later, ignite his all-conquering run in Cairo.

In September 2025, the ISSF caravan set up camp in China for the fourth World Cup of the calendar. With one shot to go in the 10 metre air pistol qualification, Samrat was comfortably inside the top eight. In his head, he was already in the final of his debut World Cup. After all, this was a routine he had executed thousands of times, in practice halls, at his father's makeshift range back home, and through endless dry firing.

Then came the unravelling. As the screen flashed 9.9 and his name slipped to 10th, Samrat says he could hear the range fall silent. It felt as if the world had caved in. But he regained his composure quickly.

"I realised I shouldn't think too far ahead. My mind was already on the finals, which shouldn't have been the case. What that failure taught me was that even if it is the last shot, I need to shoot it like my first and aim for as high a score as possible," a worn but wiser Samrat tells *Sportstar* on the sidelines of the 2026 Aces Awards in Mumbai. Back at the drawing board, he realised time was not on his side with the World Championship looming. The preparation that followed involved long conversations, mostly with himself.

"Whenever I get low scores, I tell myself to step back and take deep breaths. I remind myself there will be opportunities to course-correct, and I should make full use of them. When the pistol aligns with the black circle, you have only a few seconds before releasing the shot. There should be no second thoughts when pressing the trigger," Samrat says.

Whether he had second thoughts in Cairo on November 10, 2025, is something we will never know. But nerves would have been inevitable. After all, China's Hu Kai stood between him and the Worlds title.

Kai had been unstoppable that season, sweeping the 10m air pistol